

MOVE YOUR MOOD.

YOUR EXERCISE FOR MENTAL HEALTH GUIDE

Practical ways to use movement to support mood, energy and mental wellbeing, alongside the care that's right for you.



Created by Accredited Exercise Physiologists

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50%

reduction in the life-expectancy gap targeted by global exercise strategy

2018

joint international consensus statement on exercise & mental illness

8

accessible exercises to start with

MORE THAN FITNESS.

Movement is now treated as an active part of mental health care, not a lifestyle add-on.

2018

In 2018, ESSA joined the American College of Sports Medicine and other international bodies in a consensus statement on exercise and the life-expectancy gap in mental illness.

1

IT SHIFTS BRAIN CHEMISTRY

Activity releases the chemicals that lift mood and take the edge off anxiety.

2

IT GIVES THE DAY SHAPE

Sessions bring routine, achievement and something to show up for.

3

IT LOOKS AFTER THE BODY TOO

Physical health often suffers alongside mental illness. Movement covers both.

MYTH VS FACT

MYTH

Exercise is just about physical fitness.

FACT

Regular movement has well-documented effects on mood, anxiety and depression.

MYTH

You need intense workouts to feel it.

FACT

Consistent moderate activity, even short walks, is linked to real improvements.

MYTH

Exercise replaces other support.

FACT

It works best alongside your GP, psychologist or psychiatrist – not instead of them.

WORTH DISCUSSING WITH YOUR TEAM IF

✓ Low mood or anxiety makes starting hard

✓ Medication affects your energy or motivation

✓ You'd like a structured plan to follow

The good news: exercise is now an evidence-based part of mental health treatment. Even modest amounts of movement can improve mood, energy and quality of life.

FOUR THINGS IT DOES FOR YOU.

Exercise affects the brain and body in ways that directly support mental wellbeing, alongside its physical benefits.

1

LIFTS MOOD

Physical activity releases feel-good brain chemicals, and the effect often shows up the same day.

2

EASES ANXIETY

Regular movement is linked to lower day-to-day anxiety and better coping with stress.

3

IMPROVES SLEEP

Consistent activity supports more regular, restful sleep, often disrupted by mental illness.

4

BUILDS CONNECTION

Group or supervised exercise brings routine, social contact and support.

WHAT HELPS IT STICK

Choose activities you genuinely enjoy

Start small – don't aim for perfect

Exercise with others – a friend, group or AEP

Judge it on how you feel afterwards

The 2018 international consensus statement, co-authored by ESSA, recommends accessible, appropriately supervised exercise as part of routine mental health care.

WEEKS 1-2

Building a small, manageable routine

WEEKS 3-6

Noticeable improvements in mood and energy for many people

ONGOING

Exercise as a sustainable part of your toolkit

START HERE.

Accessible exercises to build a sustainable routine. Choose what feels achievable today, because consistency matters more than intensity.

1

BRISK WALKING OUTDOORS

A walk outside at a comfortable pace, combining movement with fresh air and daylight.

10–20 minutes, most days

2

BODYWEIGHT SQUATS

Stand and lower into a squat as far as comfortable, then return to standing, to build strength.

2 sets of 8–10 reps

3

WALL PUSH-UPS

Hands on a wall at shoulder height, bend and straighten your elbows to build upper body strength.

2 sets of 8–10 reps

4

STANDING MARCHING

March gently on the spot, a simple, low-barrier way to get moving indoors.

2–3 sets of 30–60 seconds

5

GENTLE STRETCHING OR YOGA FLOW

A short, flowing sequence of gentle stretches to connect movement and breath.

5–10 minutes

6

STEP-UPS (LOW STEP)

Step up and down onto a low, sturdy step, combining gentle cardio and strength.

2 sets of 8–10 reps each leg

7

RESISTANCE BAND PULLS

Gently pull a light resistance band apart or towards you to build upper body strength.

2 sets of 10–12 reps

8

MINDFUL BREATHING OR GROUNDING

A few minutes of slow, focused breathing to settle the mind before or after activity.

3–5 minutes, as needed



BEFORE YOU START

Start with whatever feels manageable today, because even a short walk counts. If low mood or anxiety is making it hard to begin, an Accredited Exercise Physiologist can help build a gentle, structured plan alongside your GP or mental health professional.

SHOWING UP IS THE WIN.

A simple, flexible routine to build consistency. Adjust the pace to what feels achievable, because some movement is always better than none.

DAY	FOCUS	WHAT TO DO
MON / WED / FRI	Strength	Bodyweight squats + Wall push-ups + Resistance band pulls
TUE / THU	Aerobic	A brisk walk outdoors or standing marching indoors
EVERY DAY	Mind-body	A few minutes of mindful breathing or gentle stretching
WEEKENDS	Connect	Exercise with a friend, a group, or however feels enjoyable

WEEK 1-2

Focus on simply showing up, even for a short session, and building routine.

WEEK 3-6

Gradually build duration or frequency as it feels manageable.

BEYOND

A supervised program helps keep exercise sustainable as part of your broader care.

FROM YOUR HEP TEAM

SUPPORT THAT FITS ALONGSIDE YOUR CARE

Our Accredited Exercise Physiologists work alongside your GP, psychologist or psychiatrist to build a gentle, achievable exercise plan that supports your mental health goals.

BOOK ONLINE

www.hobartexercisephysiology.com.au

WHERE THIS COMES FROM.

Every recommendation in this guide is drawn from peer-reviewed research and professional body position statements.

- 01** Stubbs, B., Vancampfort, D., Hallgren, M., Firth, J., Veronese, N., Solmi, M., et al. (2018) 'EPA guidance on physical activity as a treatment for severe mental illness', *European Psychiatry*, 54, pp. 124–144.
- 02** Exercise & Sports Science Australia, American College of Sports Medicine, British Association of Sport and Exercise Sciences & Sport and Exercise Science New Zealand (2018) *The role of sport, exercise, and physical activity in closing the life expectancy gap for people with mental illness* [Joint international consensus statement]. Available at: essa.org.au (Accessed: 2026).
- 03** Exercise & Sports Science Australia, Australian Psychological Society & Dietitians Australia (2017) *Addressing the physical health of people with mental illness* [Position statement]. Available at: essa.org.au (Accessed: 2026).
- 04** Exercise Right (2018) *Exercise & Mental Health* [eBook]. Exercise & Sports Science Australia. Available at: exerciseright.com.au (Accessed: 2026).

A NOTE ON ADVICE

This guide is for general educational purposes and is not a substitute for professional mental health care. Exercise works best alongside, not instead of, support from your GP, psychologist or psychiatrist. Speak with an Accredited Exercise Physiologist to build a plan suited to you.